

Moratorium on high rise

ARCHITECTURE ROBERT CAMPBELL

A few miles south of Florence, in the Tuscany region of Italy, a small town sits on a hill. The town is San Gimignano, and as anyone knows who has been there, it is remarkable for its 13 towers.

The towers were built in the Middle Ages by noble families of the town, originally for defense. They also had a symbolic meaning.

As the Michelin Guide puts it: "For reasons of prestige, each lord built his tower as high as he could."

Boston does not have wealthy lords, but its wealthy corporations occupy the same social role. Thus Lord Hancock and Lord Prudential, with their rival towers, are acting out a ritual that is as old as the glass mirror-wall is new. So, too, were the proprietors of the Empire State Building when they recently came up with a duck-brained scheme to add floors on top of the building to make it the world's tallest again.

The point of this isn't to put down the developers of any of these towers, ancient or modern. Quite the opposite.

For the fact is that San Gimignano is really beautiful, and part of what makes it so beautiful is the soaring effect of the towers reaching up from the hill toward the sky. They give you the kind of thrill people used to get from the Manhattan skyline.

Like it or not, there is something exciting about high buildings in cities. Like nothing else since the Gothic cathedrals, modern skyscrapers can symbolize power and aspiration. They can give a city a more visible shape and form. To those who work in them, they can offer spectacular views.

So why, then, do we hear a growing, seemingly nationwide, outcry against these buildings?

Because there are getting to be too many of them too close together.

When that happens, the buildings don't symbolize aspiration but rather congestion. Instead of that spectacular view, the inhabitants see only the skyscraper next door. Problems multiply—dark and windy sidewalks, overloaded transportation systems, inadequate shopping, restaurant, and recreation facilities.

Worse yet, the high buildings create a need for each other that drives out other uses. It happens this way: The first tall building is built in a neighborhood, and is financially successful. As a result, developers decide this is a good neighborhood for tall buildings. This opinion quickly drives land values in the neighborhood so high that, in order to get back what he paid for his land, a developer has to build as tall as he can. It's a self-fulfilling prophecy, a classic circle.

Up to now, Boston has been lucky enough to avoid most of this (and that's one reason people are flocking to live here).

For years, bad soil conditions prevented high-rise. Later, when the technical problems had been solved, a rare combination of urban-renewal clout and wealthy institutional developers, like Prudential, made it possible for some of the high-rise, when it came, to be located in what were then unfashionable locations, instead of all jammed into a few blocks of downtown.

Meanwhile, citizen's groups were keeping the new growth out of residential neighborhoods such as Back Bay.

The result was a thin, strung-out line of high-rise stretching from the Christian Science Center to downtown that has so far done little violence to the character of the city, while at the same time giving some economic vitality and even a clearer visual form to Boston.

But that won't last long if it's left up to private developers. They will take the safe course and locate each new building right next door to another, already successful one. The result: jammed, dense over-crowding, with all the problems it brings.

It is for this reason that more and more people are calling for at least some kind of moratorium on high-rise in Boston, something like the governor's highway moratorium, to stay in effect until the city can come up with both a plan to direct growth and a means to implement it.

If that happened, the hope is that land speculation would slow down and renovation of older buildings would start.

It wouldn't really be a radical step because, although few persons know it, Boston already has a height limit. Under present zoning in downtown, you can't cover your site with a building higher than about 10 or 11 stories.

The law hasn't been implemented for so long that it's a laughing-stock, but it might be a place to begin.

In last week's column critical reference was made to the new Federal Reserve Building, which hasn't been built yet. The reference was intended for the First National Bank Building.